

Shah Burj Gate / Hathi Pol ("Elephant Gate")

ہاتھی پول دروازہ

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Not individually documented; part of the Shah Burj Quadrangle building programme under Shah Jahan
- Built in: Shah Jahan's reign (early-to-mid 17th century), alongside the adjoining Elephant Path
- Cost: Not documented
- Built for: The private royal entrance to the residential northern quarters of the fort, reserved for the imperial family and household rather than the general public

2. Construction Details

- Materials: Integrated structurally into the exterior of the Picture Wall ensemble
- Technique: Positioned at the southwest corner of the Elephant Path courtyard as its only original entrance
- Artisans/craftsmen involved: Not documented
- Time taken: Not documented

3. Historical Background

- Functioned as the private royal gateway connecting the outside world to the Shah Burj Quadrangle's residential apartments, in contrast to the Akbari and Alamgiri Gates, which handled public and ceremonial traffic.
- Its exterior face forms part of the larger Picture Wall, meaning anyone approaching this private entrance from outside the fort would have walked past some of the most richly tiled and painted surfaces in the entire complex.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- Because it connects directly to the Elephant Path, this gate was quite literally sized and placed for elephant traffic carrying members of the royal household - not foot traffic.
- Unlike the grand public gates, Hathi Pol was designed to be discreet and secure rather than monumental, reflecting its private function.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Picture a summer evening in the 1630s: the empress's household is returning from an outing, and instead of the crowded public gates, their elephants turn quietly toward Hathi Pol - a side door in a palace wall that happens to be covered, floor to roofline, in glazed tile pictures of hunts and processions, as if the wall itself were narrating the very journey the household was making.